three, Australia went on to run up a very big score, with skipper Michael Clarke contributing a triple hundred to their 659, and this left us two whole days to bat to save the match.

Batting for two days was difficult but not impossible. At the end of day three, I was unbeaten on eight, having faced forty deliveries. I was batting to a plan and was determined to leave everything outside off stump. It had got a little cloudy in the evening and with Ben Hilfenhaus and Peter Siddle bowling really well, I was satisfied to survive the last hour so that I could resume the following morning.

Before I walked out to bat on the fourth day, our masseur Amit Shah wished me luck and I said to him that he should get ready to keep me going for two days. I knew that if I did so I would be able to save the game, and if the 100th ton should come along the way, so much the better. Once again I was batting well and should have gone on, but infuriatingly I got myself out to part-time left-arm spinner Michael Clarke for 80 to a ball which pitched around off stump on a fourth-day pitch with a few cracks and, just as I was trying to play forward, kissed the outside edge of my bat and hit Brad Haddin on his thigh before going to Mike Hussey at slip.

It was a soft dismissal. I had actually told myself to wait an over before starting to attack Clarke, who was bowling with a semi-defensive field. A very strong wind was blowing and I wanted to wait for it to die down before I risked stepping out and hitting him over mid off. It was just one of those moments in the game that you are not able to control, moments that make cricket one of the most challenging of all sports.

Despite scoring 73, 32, 41 and 80 in the first four innings in Australia, the talk about me ‘failing’ had resumed and the consensus among the critics was that I was getting out because I was thinking too much about the 100th hundred. Such comments were sometimes hard to take, because for me playing for my country has always come first. The critics were welcome to give their opinions, but none of them had ever been in my predicament and it was impossible for them to understand what I was thinking or feeling.

After Sydney, the series went steadily downhill for us at Perth and Adelaide. We should have played much better and I must say the eight-Test-match losing streak on foreign soil was very difficult to come to terms with. Our team had not lived up to its potential and had been outplayed in all departments. It was a very trying time.